



New dawn: If Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo define the age passing by, Lamine Yamal may come to define the one taking shape. GETTY IMAGES

as Uzbekistan, Jordan, Cape Verde and Mali, which once viewed qualification as a distant dream, are now part of football's biggest stage. The World Cup is no longer a championship contested solely by football's traditional elite.

Of course, expansion is also about money.

More teams create more inventory, more broadcast windows, more sponsorship integrations, more streaming subscriptions and more advertising opportunities.

Inclusivity and commercial growth are not mutually exclusive.

Even player-welfare measures now carry commercial possibilities. The North American summer is expected to become one of the defining stories of the tournament. Afternoon kick-offs in parts of the United States and Mexico can be brutally demanding, with players arriving after increasingly overloaded club seasons. FIFA's decision to implement additional cooling and drinks breaks is sensible

from a medical perspective.

But football and FIFA rarely waste an opportunity. Those stoppages also create eight extra minutes of broadcast inventory in every game, and across the course of the tournament, that translates into a significant amount of monetisable airtime.

This, perhaps, is the defining story of the 2026 World Cup. Football is stretched by politics and commerce, forced to navigate the contradictions of the age it inhabits.